

Class Meeting Handout 14

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Hammett plots are not always simple. In rare cases they can be curved. When this happens we have an exciting and interesting observation to explain.¹

LFER Part 3: Curved Plots

Discussion: Isokinetic Temperature – 20 minutes

Organic chemists are usually not trained to be physical chemists. That is why this course is so important. It is also the source of seemingly endless discussion around the idea of enthalpy-entropy compensation and isokinetic temperature. Despite the difficulty in handwaving a proper explanation for this observation, it is a real issue and can lead to misinterpretation of Hammett data when one is close to the isokinetic temperature.²

1. What is meant by the term “isokinetic temperature?”
2. Demonstrate how it might come about through enthalpy-entropy compensation using an Eyring plot. Using the data from problem 23 in chapter 8 might be the best approach.³
3. Hypothesize how a group that increase the enthalpy of a transition state (slower reaction) can increase the entropy (faster reaction). Do you believe your explanations are generally applicable or specific to a given case?
4. Consider the statistical nightmare that most Eyring plots represent. How might this give you caution when considering the idea of enthalpy-entropy compensation.^{4,5,6}

Exercise: Curved Hammett Plots – 20 minutes

There are two ways a plot can be curved. If there are two different mechanisms for a reaction and they have different reaction constants, ρ , we may see one dominate and then the other as we change substituents.⁷ If there is a mechanism with multiple steps and each step has a different dependence on electron density then we may see the rate-determining-step change as we change substituents. The rate is limited by the slowest step so we will see only the slower rate. Let us explore this idea.

This document was produced using the $\text{\LaTeX}$ typesetting language with the Tufte-handout document class. Chemical diagrams were created in *ChemDoodle*. Plots were typeset using *Matplotlib* and *Python* tools. Diagrams were created and edited using *Affinity Designer*.

¹ Read chapter 8.3, 8.4 and 8.6.

² Read ch. 8.6

³ You will already have done these calculations as the problem was assigned to be completed before class.

⁴ Honestly, the Eyring plot is actually worse than the Lineweaver-Burke plot – and that’s saying something.

⁵ “The Enthalpy-Entropy Relationship and its Implications for Organic Chemistry.” J.E. Leffler, *J. Org. Chem.*, **1955**, *20*, 1202-1231. <https://doi.org/10.1021/jo01126a009>

⁶ “The Isokinetic Relationship.” W. Linert, *Chem. Soc. Rev.*, **1989**, *18*, 477-505. <https://doi.org/10.1039/CS9891800477>

⁷ This is similar to pH-rate profiles where multiple pathways are operating and we only see the largest contributor in each region of the plot. In a log-log plot we are exploring rate with orders of magnitude in the difference.

1. Create two linear Hammett plots that cross (have the same rate) when we are using m-Cl as the substituent. Plot them both on the same graph.⁸

- Add the two plots together over a range of σ values. This is analogous to two different mechanisms contributing to the overall rate. What does it look like?
- Only plot the line with the greater rate of the two over a range of σ values. This is analogous to the slower reaction being the r.d.s. What does it look like?

2. Consider the hydrolysis of nitrosamines as shown in figure 1. These are carcinogenic byproducts of keeping red meat red by adding nitrite salts.⁹ The reactions of such compounds in water would be important to study. Let us consider a Hammett plot of the hydrolysis of nitrosamines in acidic conditions. I found data for this reaction in a textbook¹⁰ which referenced a very obscure Russian journal article as the source of the data.¹¹ I have not yet been able to find this article. I cannot even prove that this journal ever existed. So I digitized the data from figure 4.5 in the textbook.

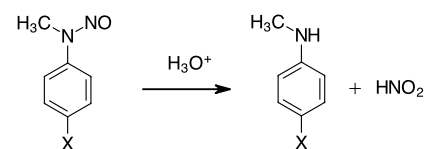
- Propose a mechanism for the acid hydrolysis of a nitrosamine.
- Now propose a different mechanism. For example, if the first mechanism features protonation followed by departure of the nitroso group, this one could have departure precede protonation.
- Plot the data presented in table 2 on page 5 as a Hammett plot. What do you observe? Determine values for the reaction constant(s), ρ .
- Reconcile your observation with the proposed mechanisms.

3. We have seen the hydrolysis of benzyl chlorides and used Hammett plots to explore the mechanism. Let us now consider the solvolysis of benzyl tosylates in acetic acid¹² as shown in figure 2.

- What is the tosylate group and why is it a common group in synthetic organic chemistry?
- Based on what you know about solvolysis of benzyl chloride in water and ethanol, propose a mechanism for this reaction.
- Table 3 on page 5 presents rate data for a series of substituted benzyl tosylates. Plot this data as a Hammett plot. What do you observe?
- The mechanism is believed to be S_N2 for benzyl tosylates in acetic acid because inversion is observed at the benzyl carbon. Given this fact propose an explanation for the Hammett plot.¹³

⁸ How do you obtain a line equation for a line with a given slope that passes through a given point? Just do that twice.

Figure 1: Acid hydrolysis of a nitrosamine

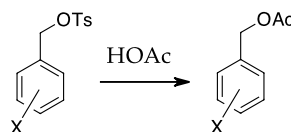


⁹ "An Organic Chemist's Guide to N-Nitrosamines: Their Structure, Reactivity, and Role as Contaminants." J.C. Beard, T.M. Swager, *J. Org. Chem.*, 2021, 86, 2037-2057. <https://doi.org/10.1021/acs.joc.0c02774>

¹⁰ "Physical Organic Chemistry, 2nd ed." by Neil Isaacs. 1995, Wiley, New York (the 1st edition is available in UPEI library stacks QD476.I846 1987.)

¹¹ B.A. Porai-Koshits, E.Y. Belyaev, E. Shadovskii, *React. Sposobnost. Org. Soedin.*, 1964, 1, 10.

Figure 2: Acetolysis of benzyl tosylates



¹² "Acetolysis reactivities of substituted benzyl and polycyclic arylmethyl p-toluenesulfonates. Correlations with SCF- π and CNDO MO methods." A. Streitwieser Jr., e. al., *J. Am. Chem. Soc.*, 1970, 92, 5141-5150 <https://doi.org/10.1021/ja00720a025>

¹³ Ch. 11.5 discusses S_N1/S_N2 substitutions. Ch. 11.5.8 has a nice summary.

4. The hydrolysis of imines is a great subject for physical organic chemistry. The rate data for the hydrolysis of a set of imines based on substituted anilines¹⁴ is presented in table 4 on page 6. The reaction scheme is shown in figure 3.

- Based on what you know about the formation and hydrolysis of imines in water, propose a mechanism for this reaction.
- Plot the rate data from table 4 as a Hammett plot. What do you observe?
- Explain how the proposed mechanism is consistent with the Hammett plot.¹⁵

5. Now let us examine the cyclodehydration of 2-phenyltriarylcarbinols¹⁶ as shown in figure 4. The rate data is collected in table 5 on page 6

- Based on what you know about the formation of carbocations and electrophilic aromatic substitution, propose a mechanism for this reaction.
- Plot the rate data from table 5 as a Hammett plot. What do you observe?
- Explain how your proposed mechanism is consistent with the Hammett plot.¹⁷

That was a lot of plotting and it is highly unlikely that we will be able to explore all four data sets described above during the class meeting. You should plot any that we miss and compare your conclusions with your peers. You will learn much more about data analysis if you do it yourself.

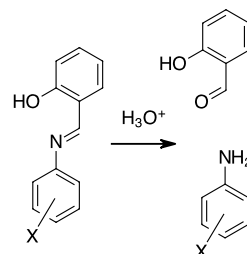
Discussion: Preparing for Your Exploration – 10 minutes

Along with this handout, explorations of a literature contributions featuring curved Hammett plots are available on the moodle site. These are examples of the kind of work that I will be looking for when you submit your exploration report six weeks from now. We will revisit these explorations when we begin the second phase of this course where we will apply the principles of physical organic chemistry to as many examples as possible. Any requests?

In class we will discuss expectations for the exploration report and hopefully start you on your way to writing you own.

¹⁴ "Kinetics of hydrolysis of substituted salicylideneanilines." J. Hoffmann, J. Klicnar, V. Štěrbá, M. Večeřa, *Coll. Czech. Chem. Comm.*, **1970**, *35*, 1387–1398. <http://doi.org/10.1135/cccc19701387>

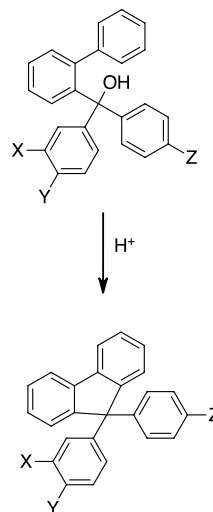
Figure 3: Hydrolysis of salicylideneaniline



¹⁵ Ch. 10.15 discusses imine formation and catalysis.

¹⁶ "Mechanism of cyclodehydration of 2-phenyltriarylcarbinols", H. Hart, E.A. Sedor, *J. Am. Chem. Soc.*, **1967**, *89*, 2342–2347. <https://doi.org/10.1021/ja00986a018>

Figure 4: Cyclodehydration of 2-phenyltriarylcarbinols



¹⁷ Ch. 10.18 discusses electrophilic aromatic substitution and ch. 9.2 discusses the rate acceleration resulting from intramolecular mechanisms.

Learning Goals

Through the suggested textbook reading, problems, participating in this class discussion, and reading the sample exploration report, students will...

- have become familiar with the concept of isokinetic temperature as it applies to Hammett plots. Also, students will hopefully appreciate the controversy around this idea and take it with a grain of salt.
- have explored more complex reaction schemes and observe how LFER plots can curve depending on the changing relative rates of the steps or pathways.
- have gained more experience interpreting literature examples and following descriptions of chemical synthesis.
- **Computer Skill:** have again used an interactive *Python* notebook to interpret and analyze experimental data from the literature.

A Look Ahead

We have completed our investigation of electronic effects of substitution. But, the whole Hammett plot idea is rigged by the use of only *m*- and *p*-substituted benzene rings as probes for electronic effects. In the Hammett approach the steric demand of the phenyl group w.r.t. the reaction centre never changes. What if our changing groups also had very different steric interference? We will now need a score for steric effects.

In the second half of lesson #3 we will survey other LFER systems and use parameters that describe steric effects of substituents and effects of solvents on the rates of a reaction. We will also enjoy a brief overview of the many other clever methods one could use to design an experiment for investigating the mechanism of a reaction.

Explorations to Come

The data sets presented today are from literature contributions. For the data sets presented today I have written the following explorations that will be available via the moodle site.¹⁸

1. "Plots for Hydrolysis of Nitrosamines"¹⁹
2. "Exploration: Solvolysis of Benzyltosylates"²⁰
3. "Plots for Hydrolysis of salicylideneanilines"²¹
4. "Exploration: Cyclodehydration"²²

¹⁸ When I go and find data, I often end up travelling down a rabbit hole as I try to interpret exactly how the data was obtained and what it means. I will follow references that the author claim support their conclusions and the rabbit hole gets deeper. Almost always I find small errors or decide to interpret the data differently. Then I write a critical review of the work so that I have a record of my thoughts and analysis.

¹⁹ I can't explore this work because I cannot get access to the original paper. I just stole the data from a secondary source.^{10,11} This exploration is just a presentation of the plots for your reference.

²⁰ In this exploration I replotted the data and performed a curve fit optimization that I felt was more robust than the "drawing straight lines with a ruler" method that was used by the authors.¹² I revealed that the evidence of the curved line that supported a change in mechanism could be interpreted to be the deviation of a single point. This exploration is short and some more exploration of related work is needed to reach the level of effort expected for a student exploration.

²¹ I have not explored this literature contribution¹⁴ except to grab the data. I read some very recent work in which salicylideneanilines are being used as photoswitchable molecules. Also the authors present data for the alkaline hydrolysis and plot pH-rate profiles. There are references to some other work that hint at some very interesting results from other authors. Perhaps this could be a thread that you pull on as you seek a topic for your own explorations.

²² In this exploration of the work by Hart and Sedor¹⁶ I plotted the data reported in the paper and compared it to the plot presented by the authors. I observed an error in the data table. I also re-analyzed the isotope effect data so that I could strengthen my own understanding of isotope effects. I then used the data presented by the authors to calculate the order of the reaction in acid activity. To do this I had to find reported values for the acidity, H_0 , of mixtures of acetic and sulfuric acids. All of my analyses were supportive of the authors conclusions.

Data Tables

The data for the exercises is collected in this section.

Substituent	σ	σ^+	σ^-
p-OCH ₃	-0.27	-0.78	-0.26
m-OCH ₃	0.11		
p-CH ₃	-0.14	-0.31	-0.17
m-CH ₃	-0.06		
H	0		
p-F	0.06	-0.07	-0.03
p-C ₆ H ₅	0.06		
p-Cl	0.23	0.11	0.19
p-Br	0.23	0.15	0.25
m-Cl	0.37		
m-CF ₃	0.46		
p-CF ₃	0.53		0.65
p-CO ₂ Et	0.54		0.64
p-NO ₂	0.78		1.24

Table 1: σ values for selected substituents.

Substituent	$k / 10^{-5} \text{ s}^{-1}$
p-OCH ₃	11.59
p-CH ₃	6.03
H	2.04
p-Ph	0.52
p-F	1.58
p-Cl	2.05
p-Br	2.38
p-COOEt	57.41
p-NO ₂	293.76

Table 2: Acid hydrolysis of a nitrosamine in acidic water. Conditions unknown. Data is digitized from reference [11](#)

Substituent	$k / 10^{-5} \text{ s}^{-1}$
p-CH ₃	96.3
m-CH ₃	4.54
p-F	4.19
H,	1.71
p-Cl	0.86
m-Cl	0.087
m-CF ₃	0.0446
p-CF ₃	0.0277

Table 3: Rates of solvolysis of benzyl tosylates in acetic acid at 40 °C. Data is from reference [12](#)

Substituent	$k / 10^{-3} \text{ min}^{-1}$
p-OCH ₃	4.07
p-CH ₃	7.76
m-CH ₃	8.71
H	12.59
m-OCH ₃	14.79
p-Cl	12.02
m-Cl	13.49
m-NO ₂	7.08

Table 4: Rates of hydrolysis of salicylideneanilines at pH 5.5. Data is from reference [14](#)

Reactant	X	Y	Z	$\Sigma \sigma$	$\Sigma \sigma^+$	k_{rel}
1	H	p-Cl	p-Cl	0.46	0.22	0.096
2	m-CF ₃	H	H	0.43	0.43	0.052
3	m-Cl	H	H	0.37	0.37	0.100
4	H	p-Cl	H	0.23	0.11	0.30
5	m-OCH ₃	H	H	0.12	0.12	0.74
6	H	H	H	0	0	1.00
7	m-CH ₃	H	H	-0.07	-0.07	1.48
8	H	p-CH ₃	H	-0.17	-0.31	3.27
9	H	p-OCH ₃	H	-0.27	-0.78	0.56
10	H	p-CH ₃	p-CH ₃	-0.34	-0.62	5.80
11	H	p-CH ₃	p-OCH ₃	-0.44	-1.09	0.176
12	H	p-OCH ₃	p-OCH ₃	-0.54	-1.56	0.009

Table 5: Rates of cyclodehydration of 2-Phenyltriarylcarbinols in 80 % aqueous acetic acid containing 4 % sulfuric acid. Rates are reported as relative rates. The rate constant for the unsubstituted case, **6**, is $2.54 \times 10^{-3} \text{ s}^{-1}$. Data from reference [16](#)

